

Amalini Fernando

amalinifernando@gmail.com | LinkedIn | Albany, NY

SUMMARY

PhD candidate in public policy specializing in data privacy & technology regulation. Experience in academia, government & nonprofit sectors. Skilled in policy research, stakeholder engagement, & qualitative analysis. Committed to advancing equitable & effective technology policies through evidence-based advocacy & public engagement.

EDUCATION

University at Albany (SUNY)

Albany, USA

PhD in Political Science

Expected 2027

- Research interests: Data privacy, privacy regulation, data governance, emerging tech regulation
- Committee members: Prof. Patricia Strach (chair), Prof. Luis Luna-Reyes, Dr. Virginia Eubanks

University at Albany (SUNY)

Albany, USA

Master of Arts in Political Science

2026

University of Kelaniya

Kelaniya, Sri Lanka

Bachelor of Arts (Honors) in International Studies

2019

- First Class Honors (4.0 GPA) & gold medalist
- Dissertation title: “*Popular geopolitics in motion pictures: a study of select James Bond movies of their representation of the Cold War*”

RESEARCH

Conference Presentations

- *The California Effect revisited: state consumer privacy laws beyond California.* At New York State Political Science Association Conference; [Accepted]
- *Who writes the law: model legislation and interest group influence in consumer data privacy policy.* At Northeastern Political Science Association Conference; [Accepted]
- *Copy, paste, pass: how model legislation shapes consumer data privacy policy in the U.S.* At New England Political Science Association Conference; April 2026; Burlington, VT.
- *Disability discrimination in AI-enabled hiring: policy gaps & regulatory solutions.* At AI Plus Symposium; March 2026; Albany, NY.
- *A comparative study of data privacy regulations across the United States.* At Midwest Political Science Association Conference; March 2025; Chicago, IL.
- *A comparative study of data privacy regulations in California & New York.* At New York State Political Science Association Conference; April 2024; Albany, NY.
- *Moderating conspiracy theories on social media.* At University at Albany Student Research Showcase; April 2023; Albany, NY.
- *Goodbye buttons & bumper stickers, hello NFTs: NFTs as the newest political fundraising tool.* At Midwest Political Science Association Conference; April 2023; Chicago, IL.
- *Bretton Woods out, Beijing in: examining China’s rising institutional power to change the rules-based liberal international order.* At Institutions and Societies Conference; February 2022; Albany, NY.
- *Promoting Sri Lankan cuisine to the world: lessons from Thailand.* At International Conference on Heritage as Soft Power; December 2019; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.
- *Soft power of Korean popular culture in Sri Lanka.* At International Conference on Social Sciences; December 2018; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.
- *Popular geopolitics in Cold War movies: a study of selected James Bond movies on their representation of the Cold War.* At International Studies Students’ Research Symposium; December 2018; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.
- *Postage stamps as political messengers: a study of political image building of the J. R. Jayawardana era.* At National Conference on Mass Communication; December 2018; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.

- *Korean wave in Sri Lanka: past, present, future*. At Undergraduate Research Symposium; October 2018; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.
- *Exporting power: opportunities and challenges for India in fulfilling Sri Lanka's energy demand*. At International Studies Students' Research Symposium; November 2017; Kelaniya, Sri Lanka.

Academic Publications

- *From Korean Oppas to Bibimbap: The Socio-cultural Dynamics of the Korean Wave in Sri Lanka*. In Kumar, R. & Das, B. eds. *Korean Wave in South Asia: Transcultural Flow, Fandom & Identity*. Palgrave Macmillan. 2022.
- *Promoting gastrodiploamacy to aid the recovery of Sri Lanka's tourism sector in the post-COVID-19 era: lessons from Thailand's gastrodiploamacy model*. Samaja Vimarsana, 4(1), 2021.
- *Brexit: the exit of the United Kingdom from the European Union*. In Siwudesa. Department of International Studies, University of Kelaniya, 2019. ISBN 978-955-704-015-8
- *Popular geopolitics and motion pictures: Cold war in James Bond movies*. Journal of International Studies, 5(1), 2019.

Op-Eds, Policy Briefs and Other

- *The end of one-time education: why you'll go back to college in midlife*. Op-ed: Medium; February 2026.
- *The role of afterschool, summer, & other expanded learning programs in improving early literacy outcomes*. Policy brief: New York State Network for Youth Success (NYSNYS); October 2024.
- *Can gastrodiploamacy revive tourism in Sri Lanka?* Policy brief: Lakshman Kadirgamar Institute of International Relations & Strategic Studies; October 2019.

Acknowledgments

- Acknowledged contribution to *Quantum Strategic Plan* of SUNY System Administration – Office of Research, Innovation and Economic Development; February, 2026.
- Acknowledged contribution to *Generational Politics in the United States: From the Silents to Gen Z and Beyond*. Friedman, S., & Schultz, D. eds. 2024. University of Michigan Press.

Editorial Experience

- Co-editor, *Journal of International Studies*, 6(1), 2019. Department of International Studies, University of Kelaniya. ISSN 2420-7314.
- Co-editor, Conference Abstract Volume of 3rd International Studies Students' Research Symposium 2019. Department of International Studies, University of Kelaniya. ISSN 2659-2207.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Adjunct Lecturer

June 2025–Present

Department of Political Science, University at Albany (SUNY)

Albany, New York

- Design and teach undergraduate and masters courses.
 - RPOS 303: What the Government Does and Why It Does It [formerly: Public Policy in Theory and Practice] (Summer 2025 & 2026, Asynchronous/Undergraduate; Fall 2026, Synchronous/Undergraduate)
 - RPOS 399: Information Policy in the US (Fall 2025, Synchronous/Undergraduate)
 - RPOS 522: Politics and Policy (Winter 2025, Asynchronous/Masters)
- Provide individualized academic support & feedback to students in asynchronous online & in-person formats.

Research Project Assistant

September 2026–Present

Center for Women in Government & Civil Society, Rockefeller College

Albany, New York

- Help design, launch and evaluate a holistic workforce-development program for immigrants and refugees in New York state.
- Collaborate with immigrant- and refugee-serving organizations, workforce agencies, educational institutions, employers, and public agencies to conduct interdisciplinary policy research.

Legislative Fellow

January 2026–June 2026

Office of Senator Patricia Fahy, New York State Senate

Albany, New York

- Conducted legislative research, monitored policy developments, and supported bill drafting across a range of issue areas.

- Engaged with state agencies, advocacy organizations, business stakeholders, and constituents to analyze policy issues, prepare briefing materials, and support legislative priorities.

Grants and Research Assistant

June 2025–December 2025

Office of Research, Innovation & Economic Development, SUNY System Administration Albany, New York

- Provided research support for strategy documents on Microelectronic Packaging, Biotechnology & Biomanufacturing, AI, and Quantum Computing.
- Compiled grant applications to state and federal agencies, including to NYSERDA for \$50,000 of funding to organize a SUNY-wide task force on climate resilience.

Teaching & Research Assistant

August 2021–August 2025

Department of Political Science, University at Albany (SUNY) Albany, New York

- Assisted faculty with both teaching & research responsibilities in undergraduate political science courses.
 - RPOS 101: American Politics (Spring and Fall 2023-2024)
 - RPOS 333: Women and the Law (Spring and Fall 2022)
- Contributed to various studies by scraping, cleaning, & organizing data for analysis.
 - Co-author of *An Assessment of Undergraduate and Graduate Programs in Political Science at the University at Albany*. A report developed on behalf of the Department of Political Science (2025)
 - Research assistance to a project on *mythologizing of AI in mass media*. By Stefan Kehlenbach (work in progress)
 - Research assistance to *Generational Politics in the United States: From the Silents to Gen Z and Beyond*. By Friedman, S., & Schultz, D. eds. University of Michigan Press (2024)
 - Research assistance to *The Difficult Politics of Peace: Rivalry in Modern South Asia*. By Christopher Clary. New York: Oxford University Press (2022)

Policy Intern

Summer 2024

Empire State Development Albany, New York

- Drafted a departmental proposal for the Governor's State of the State (SOTS) address for 2025.
- Researched & prepared briefing materials on topics & issues related to the semiconductor industry for the GO-SEMI project under the office of the COO.

Public Policy Intern

Summer 2023

New York State Network for Youth Success Albany, New York

- Authored a policy brief on afterschool, summer & expanded learning opportunities, funded by the Equity Partnership Program grant from The Education Trust-New York.
- Prepared reports & briefs to promote awareness & advocacy of the benefits of expanded learning programs.

Senior Research Assistant

Summer 2022

Center for Policy Research, University at Albany Albany, New York

- Coordinated event logistics for Public Financial Management (PFM) Training for the Staff of the Parliament of Zimbabwe under Zimbabwe Parliamentary Strengthening Project (PSP), funded by USAID.
- Coordinated group meetings with high-level government entities & university staff pre & post-program.

Assistant Lecturer

July 2019 – July 2021

Department of International Studies, University of Kelaniya Kelaniya, Sri Lanka

- Designed and taught courses for undergraduate and certificate levels.
 - Indian Ocean Politics (Semester II, 2019 & 2020)
 - Foreign Policy of Sri Lanka (Semester II, 2019 & 2020)
 - Foreign Policy of India (Semester I, 2020)
- Invigilated exams, assisted with departmental work, & oversaw various non-academic student activities.

LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

- Member – Governance, Leadership, and Administration Subcommittee, University at Albany Middle States Accreditation Process (Since 2026)
- Member – Dean's Leadership Council, Rockefeller College, University at Albany (Since 2025)
- Member – University Libraries' Student Advisory Board, University at Albany (2022, 2026)

- UniBuddy Campus Ambassador – Department of Political Science, University at Albany (Since 2025)
- Vice President (Public Relations) – Fireside Toastmasters Club, Albany (2024)
- Executive Committee Member – Rockefeller Students’ Association, University at Albany (2023)
- Member – Wages and Benefits Committee, Graduate Students’ Association, University at Albany (2023)
- Member – Grants Committee, Graduate Students’ Association, University at Albany (2022)
- President – Gavel Club, University of Kelaniya (2018)
- Charter President – Model United Nations, University of Kelaniya (2016)

AWARDS & GRANTS

- The Buhmaster Family Endowment Award, Initiatives for Women Foundation, University at Albany (2026)
- Conference Travel Grant, Rockefeller College of Public Affairs & Policy, University at Albany (2025, 2026)
- Social Justice Fellowship, Institute on Immigrant Integration Research and Policy, Rockefeller Institute of Government (2026)
- Women & Public Policy Fellowship, Center for Women in Government & Civil Society, Rockefeller College of Public Affairs & Policy (Spring 2026)
- The Karen R. Hitchcock New Frontiers Fund Award, Initiatives for Women Foundation, University at Albany (2025)
- The Most Ven. Professor Bambarende Siri Seevali Thero Memorial Gold Medal, University of Kelaniya (2020)
- Gold Medal for Best Performance in International Studies, University of Kelaniya (2020)

ROUND TABLES, PANELS & MEDIA APPEARANCES

- Guest: *Many Voices, One Call* podcast, Season 6, Episode 1. SUNY Schenectady County Community College (September 2026)
- Moderator: *Policy advocates fighting at the forefront of the human rights*. New Leadership New York program at the Center for Women in Government & Civil Society (July 2026)
- Panelist: *“Korean Wave in South Asia” book discussion*. All India Communication and Media Association (January 2022)
- Panelist: *Challenges women face in the workplace: fact or fiction?* Sri Lanka Unites (June 2021)
- Moderator: *Brexit: the aftermath on national and international levels*. Rotaract Club of the University of Colombo (March 2019)

SKILLS & MEMBERSHIPS

- Memberships: International Association of Privacy Professionals (IAPP), Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA), Northeastern Political Science Association (NPSA), New England Political Science Association (NEPSA), New York State Political Science Association (NYSPAS)
- Software: R, LaTeX, WordPress, Mendeley, Microsoft Office, Asana, SPIN Funding
- Certificates: Human Subject Research by CITI (2022), Competent Communicator and Competent Leader by Toastmasters International (2019)
- Languages: Sinhala (Native), English (Advanced), French (Intermediate)
- Soft skills: Public speaking, grant writing, qualitative research
- Teaching development: Various courses & workshops related to college level teaching including Course Design Academy (2023); ACAS 601 - Seminar in College Level Teaching (Fall 2026)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.